THE GARDEN OF PERPETUAL SPRING

In April 1589, the music spilled out of the city of Lahore in a continuous stream. The musicians of the naqqar khana with their giant drums, smaller tambours, cymbals and trumpets, played their instruments with a feverish energy, while dancers twirled and swayed in front of them, both men and women. Some of the women wore long Turki–Chaghatai robes while others wore tight bodices and cholis with diaphanous odhanis, and stamped their feet and threw out their arms in the sharp, staccato movements of Kathak. Attendants rushed to and fro, distributing gifts, and handing around trays of delicacies and drinks. The women in the harem smiled to themselves, for they held a clean and glimmering secret, like the first snow on red leaves: a child had been born to a wife of Prince Salim, a daughter. We do not, in fact, know the exact details of the celebrations, often omitted from the texts. But Abu'l Fazl pointed out that 'contrary to the custom of contemporaries, it was made an occasion of rejoicing'. Once again, Akbar had decreed that the birth of a girl would be celebrated with the same gratitude and joy as that of a boy, and the exquisite details of such festivities can only be guessed at through the silent pages of the miniatures in the *Akbarnama*.

Only three weeks later, the very same city was hushed and silenced, for the musician of genius Tansen had died. 'His death,' said a grieving Akbar, 'was the annihilation of melody.' For Tansen was not just a singer, but a lyrical poet whose sensitive imagery Jahangir captured in his memoirs, demonstrating not only a sensitive appreciation of imagery but also a fine knowledge of Brajbhasha:

> Because the black bee is a constant visitor to these flowers, the Hindi poets consider it to be like the nightingale in love with the rose, and they produce marvelous poetic conceits based on it. One such poet was Tansen Kalawant, who was in my father's service and without equal in his own time—or any other for that matter. In one of his songs he likened the face of a youth to the sun and the opening of his eye to the blossoming of the lotus and the emerging